

Can Post-syntax Trigger Syntactic Change?

The Case of Korean TAM Marker *-te*

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What will be discussed?

- Mirror-Principle violation in the 15th c.
- The diachronic change of the TAM marker *-te* as a structural reanalysis
- Preference for the simplest-possible post-syntax during language acquisition (cf. Roberts 2022)

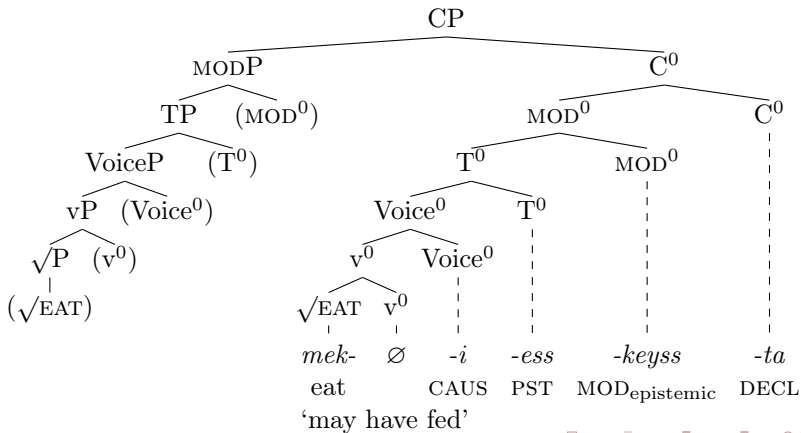
Outline

- 1 Introduction
- 2 Difference between Middle Korean and Modern Korean *-te*
- 3 Mirror-Principle violation in Middle Korean
- 4 Mirror-Principle violation as a ‘diachronic accident’
- 5 Structural reanalysis of *-te*: Toward MoK evidential marker
- 6 The order between the reanalysis and the evidentialization
- 7 Conclusion and prospects

Mirror-Principle (Baker 1985)

- Morphemes are not placed arbitrarily.
- The morphology represents the syntactic hierarchy:
 $\checkmark < \text{Voice}^0 < T^0 < \text{MOD}^0 < C^0$.

(1)



Language change and Mirror-Principle violation

What happens when a historical change gives rise to a misalignment between syntax and morphology?

- Repaired morphology?
- Violation tolerated?

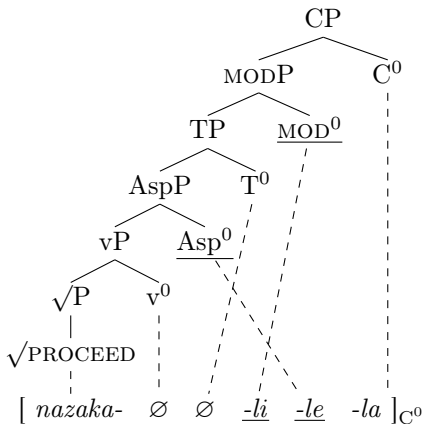
The violation may persist.

Middle Korean (MiK)

(2) *Salom-i mwot **nazaka-li-le-la**.*

person-NOM not proceed-MOD-PST.IPFV-DECL

‘People could not have gone any farther.’ (1447 *Sŏkpo sangjŏl* 24:50)



The position of *-te* (realized as *-le*) relative to MOD⁰ in MiK exemplifies the second scenario.

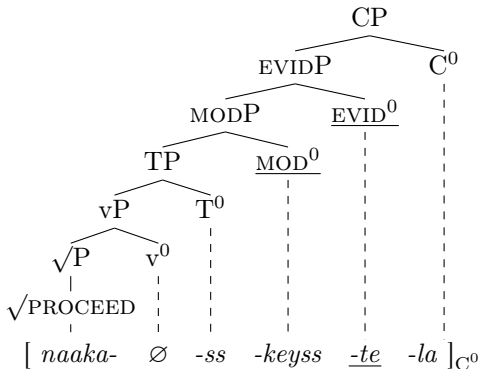
The violation may not persist forever.

Modern Korean (MoK)

(3) *Salam-i mot naaka-ss-keyss-te-la.*

person-NOM not proceed-PST-MOD-EVID-DECL

‘People could not have gone any farther.’ (MoK translation of (2))



The position of *-te* relative to MOD⁰ in MiK suggests that historical mismatch may not persist forever.

What is the driving force of language change?

Proposal:

Post-syntactic complexity induced by Mirror-Principle violation may give rise to a structural reanalysis.

Synopsis

15th c.:

MP violation



Structural reanalysis

Asp⁰ *te* → EVID⁰ *-te*



19th c.:

MP violation removed

Preference for the simplest-possible
post-syntactic module
(cf. *simplicity preference*, Roberts 2022)

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Middle Korean (MiK)

- An ancestral variety of Modern Korean (MoK) spoken from the 10th century to the 16th century.
- Reliable materials are attested from the mid-15th century (the invention of *Hangul* in 1443)



Figure: Middle Korean material (1447 *Sŏkpo sangjŏl* 11:16)

Difference between MiK *-te* and MoK *-te*

- MiK *-te*: past imperfective (Choi 2015; Lee 2020 a.o.)
- MoK *-te*: evidential (Chung 2020; Song 2020 a.o.)

(4) Middle Korean

Tasos salom-i ... kungeysye sa-te-la.

five person-NOM ... there live-PST.IPFV-DECL

‘Five people were staying there.’ (1447 *Sŏkpo sangjŏl* 3:35)

(5) Modern Korean

Taum tal-pwuthe kilum-kaps-i olu-te-la.

next month-from oil-price-NOM rise-EVID-DECL

‘The oil price rises from next month.’ (Song 2020: 416)

- Semantic and morphological differences between MiK and MoK (See Appendix I)

Subject honorific -(u)si: diagnostic for -te's position

MoK -te appears after subject honorific -(u)si

(6) Modern Korean

ha-si-te-la

do-HONS-EVID-DECL

‘do(es)/did/will do (subject honorific, evidential)’

(7) a. Middle Korean

ho-te-si-ta

do-PST.IPFV-HONS-DECL

‘was doing (subject honorific)’

b. Modern Korean

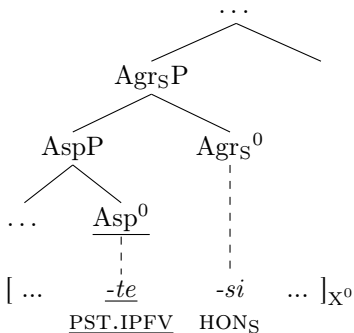
* *ha-te-si-ta*

do-PST.IPFV-HONS-DECL

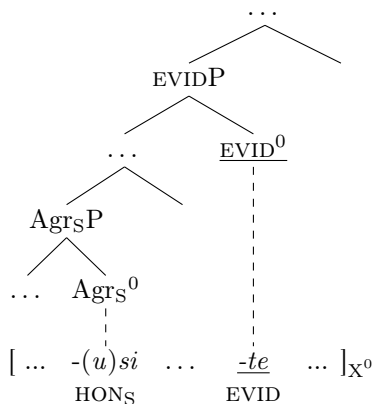
N.B. the pattern (6) is also attested in Middle Korean.

Structural position of *-te* in MiK and MoK

(8) Middle Korean



(9) Modern Korean



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MiK modal $-(u)li$

- A morpheme expressing epistemic modality such as conjecture, inference, and certainty.
- Here assumed to be $\text{MOD}^0_{\text{epistemic}}$ (abbreviated as MOD^0)

(10) *Ney api ... cwuk-uli-la.*
 your father ... die-MOD-DECL

‘Your father will (surely) die.’

(1490 *Samkanghayngsilto Enhay Hyoja* 21)

- Asp^0 *-te* is predicted to appear closer to $\sqrt{\quad}$ than MOD^0 $-(u)li$.

Mirror-Principle violation

- *-te* constantly appears after *-(u)li*:

- (11) a. $\left[\begin{array}{ccc} \checkmark & \underline{\text{MOD}^0} & \underline{\text{Asp}^0} & \text{C}^0 \\ ho & \underline{-li} & \underline{-le} & -la \\ do & \text{-MOD} & \text{-PST.IPFV} & \text{-DECL} \end{array} \right]_{\text{C}^0}$
 ‘would be going to do’
- b. $\left[\begin{array}{ccc} \checkmark & \underline{\text{Asp}^0} & \underline{\text{MOD}^0} & \text{C}^0 \\ *ho & \underline{-te} & \underline{-li} & -la \\ do & \text{-PST.IPFV} & \text{-MOD} & \text{-DECL} \end{array} \right]_{\text{C}^0}$

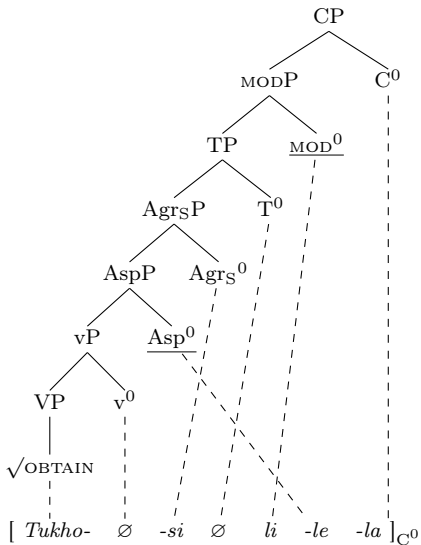
Mirror-Principle violation

- *-te* constantly appears after *-(u)li* even when Asp^0 and MOD^0 are not adjacent to each other in the structure.

- (12) a. $\left[\begin{array}{ccccc} \checkmark & \text{AGRS}^0 & \text{MOD}^0 & \text{Asp}^0 & \text{C}^0 \\ TUKho & \underline{-si} & \underline{-li} & \underline{-le} & -la \\ \text{obtain} & \text{-HONS} & \text{-MOD} & \text{-PST.IPFV} & \text{-DECL} \end{array} \right]_{\text{C}^0}$
 ‘would be going to obtain’ (hon.)
 (1459 *Wŏrin sŏkpo* 21:222a)
- b. $\left[\begin{array}{ccccc} \checkmark & \text{Asp}^0 & \text{AGRS}^0 & \text{MOD}^0 & \text{C}^0 \\ *TUKho & \underline{-te} & \underline{-si} & \underline{-li} & -la \\ \text{obtain} & \text{-PST.IPFV} & \text{-HONS} & \text{-MOD} & \text{-DECL} \end{array} \right]_{\text{C}^0}$

Mirror-Principle violation

(13)



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Section in a nutshell

The Mirror-Principle violation regarding Asp^0 *-te* and MOD^0 *-(u)li* is a diachronic ‘accident’ due to the grammaticalization of *-(u)li*.

- Asp^0 *-te* was historically higher than *-(u)li*, thereby $\sqrt{} \prec -(u)li \prec -te$
- The grammaticalization of *-(u)li* changed the structural hierarchy regarding *-te* and *-(u)li*
- Mirror-Principle violation emerged because the morphology remained the same.

The origin of $-(u)li$ and its structural position

- $-(u)li$ is grammaticalized from future relative construction (a.k.a. adnominal construction) followed by a copula $-i$ (Kim 1957; Lee 1998, 2018; Lee and Ramsey 2011; Choi 2015 a.o.).
- Choi (2026: 292) further points out that the relevant constructions are internally-headed relative clauses (IHRC) involving a head noun i .
- **The original IHRC + copula is lower than Asp⁰.**

(14) Internally-Headed Relative Clause in Middle Korean

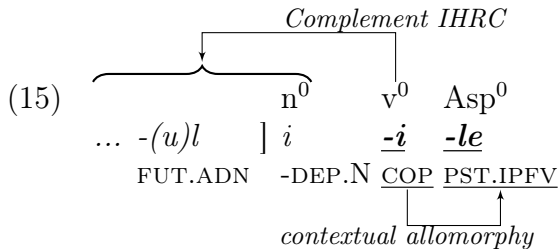
[*mwotin* YACHA TUNG SSINLYENG-*i* NGWUWCCYENG
wicked yakṣa and.so.on spirit-NOM animate.being
pwocha-l] *i* *eps-umye*
bully-FUT.ADN DEP.N not.exist-CON

‘There is no wicked yakṣa or other spirit that harm living beings ...’
(1447 *Sŏkpo sangjŏl* 9:34a)

The relative hierarchy of *-te* and *-(u)li* in the pre 15th c.

-(u)li contained a copula *-i* before the grammaticalization.

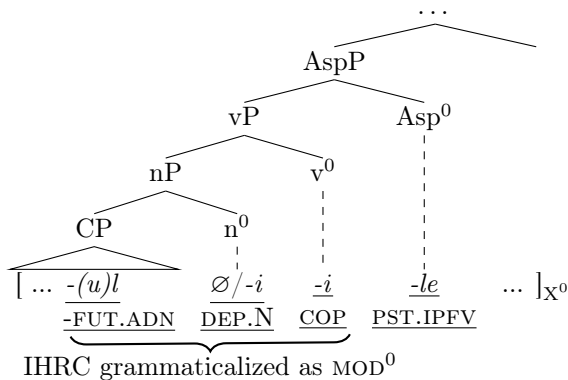
- Synchronic evidence: *-te*'s allomorphy in MiK (more on this, see Appendix II).



Pre-15th century: IHRC $-(u)li$ lower than Asp⁰

- This structure does not give rise to any Mirror-Principle violation.

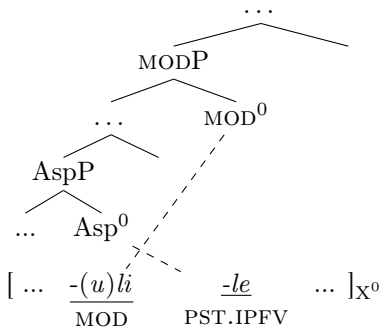
(16)



15th century: MOD⁰ -(u)li higher than Asp⁰

- -(u)li's new position involves a Mirror-Principle violation.

(17)



Asp-inversion rule

How do we account for the 15th c. morphology?

- **Asp-inversion rule**, a post-syntactic readjustment rule involving multiple steps based on the Generalized Reduplication (GenR) framework (Arregi and Nevins 2012, 2018, 2022).
- The GenR framework addresses the fact that Asp-inversion occurs even other morphemes intervene between Asp^0 and MOD^0 .

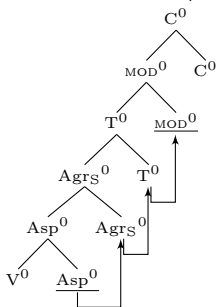
$$(18) \quad \text{Asp-inversion rule} \\ [\dots \text{Asp}^0 \dots \text{MOD}^0 \dots]_{X^0} \rightarrow [\dots \text{MOD}^0 \text{Asp}^0 \dots]_{X^0}$$

Asp-inversion rule: Derivation (detail in Appendix III)

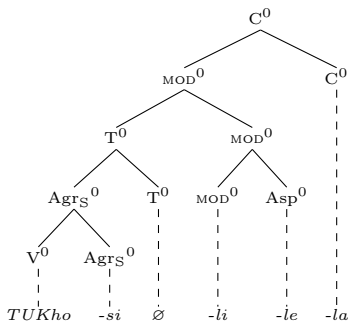
- (12a) *TUKho* *-si* *-li* *-le* *-la*
 obtain -HON_S -MOD -PST.IPFV -DECL
 ‘would be going to obtain’ (hon.)

(19) a. Asp-Inversion

($V^0 = [\sqrt{\text{OBTAIN}} \ v^0]_{V^0}$)



b. Vocabulary Insertion



Interim summary

- $-te$ is Asp^0 in MiK
- Mirror-principle violation in MiK: $-te$ is structurally lower than $-(u)li$, but linearly farther from root.
- The MP-violation is due to the fossilized morphology.
- Asp-inversion rule mediates the syntax and morphology.



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MoK *-te* is not Asp⁰, but EVID⁰.

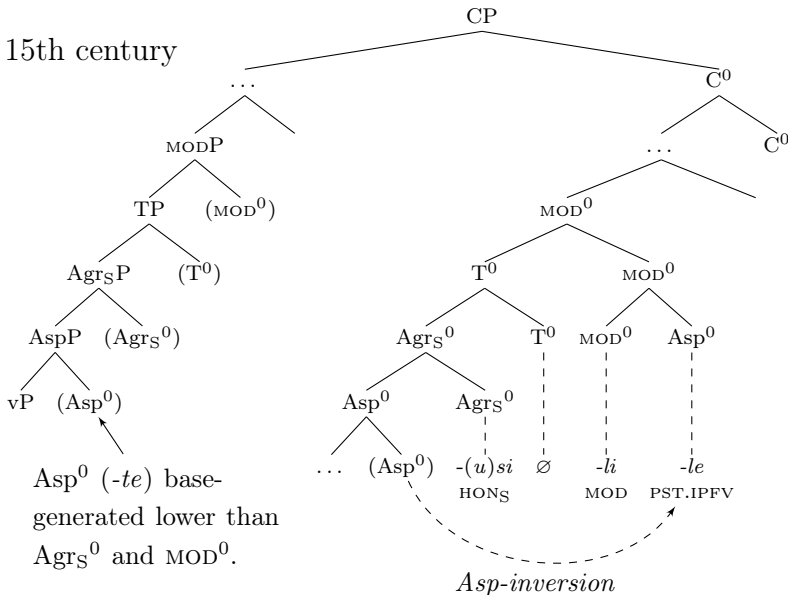
Result of a **structural reanalysis** from Asp⁰ to EVID⁰

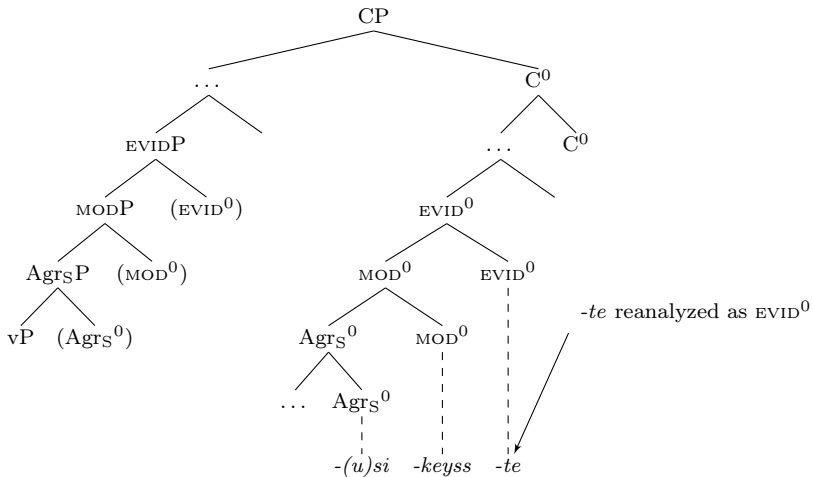
- What brought about this change, and why?
- Language acquirers' preference for the simplest possible representation of the given string in the PLD (*simplicity preference*, Roberts 2022)
i.e., the reanalysis occurred because it made the grammar simpler.
- Extension of the simplicity preference to post-syntax
- Post-syntactic complexity gave rise to a syntactic change.



Structural reanalysis of *-te*

(20) 15th century



Structural reanalysis of *-te*(21) Modern Korean¹¹The epistemic modal marker was replaced independently.

The moment of reanalysis: before the late-18th century

$-(u)si$ as a structural diagnostic

- $-te-si \rightarrow \text{Asp}^0$
- $-si-te \rightarrow \text{EVID}^0$

Pre-SH position disappears in the late 18th century (Park 2006)

- $-te$'s position changed before this point.

Simplicity preference (Roberts 2022)

(22) *Simplicity Preference* (Roberts 2022: 210)

A general preference on the part of language acquirers to assign the simplest possible structural representations to the strings they hear

- The simpler grammar is acquired for the given string unless there is sufficient evidence to the contrary.
- The simplicity is defined in terms of the number of syntactic operations, such as Merge.

(23) Two possible representations of ‘John walks’ (modified from Roberts 2022: 212)

a. John [_T walks] [_{VP} ... (walks) ...]

b. John T [_{VP} walks] *V-to-T movement*

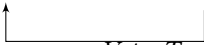
How to relate reanalysis to simplicity preference?

In Roberts's (2022) original proposal, simplicity preference addresses complexity in structural representation.

- (23) Two possible representations of 'John walks' (Roberts 2022: 212)

a. John [_T walks] [_{VP} ... (walks) ...]

b. John T [_{VP} walks] *V-to-T movement*



Post-syntactic lowering



- In both MiK and MoK, head movement happens up to C⁰ anyway.

Extension of simplicity preference to post-syntax

Proposal: Simplicity preference also operates in post-syntax *iff* syntactic complexity of the competing grammars ties.

- Post-syntactic complexity is defined in terms of the number of post-syntactic operations.
- Now, MoK grammar is simpler than MiK grammar, since it does not involve any post-syntactic operation.

	Post-syntactic operation	#
MiK	Asp-inversion rule	1
MoK	N/A	0

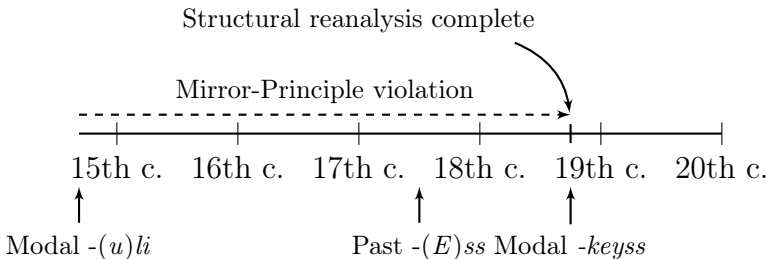
Table: Post-syntactic complexity

Delayed reanalysis problem

Why didn't structural reanalysis happen in the 15th century, but happened later on?

- The post-syntax was more complex in the 15th century than in MoK anyway.
- Later grammaticalizations increased post-syntactic complexity after the 15th century!

(24) Timeline regarding *-te*'s reanalysis



Grammaticalization of $-(E)ss$

MiK stative/resultative $-E\ is(i) \rightarrow$ MoK past $-(E)ss$

- (25) a. MiK Resultative/stative $-E\ is(i)$

Ku PIKWU-i LYEN-s-kwos wuhuy anc-a is-kenul ...
 that monk-NOM lotus-GEN-flower on sit-CON exist-as

‘As the monk is seated on a lotus flower ...’ (1447 *Sōkpo sangjöl* 24:16)

- b. MoK past $-(E)ss$

Ku pikwu-ka yenkkoch wuyey anc-ass-ta.
 that monk-NOM lotus on sit-PST-DECL

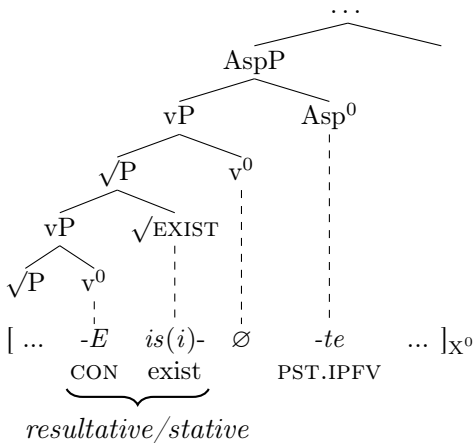
‘That monk sat on a lotus flower.’



15th century: Resultative/stative *-E is(i)-*

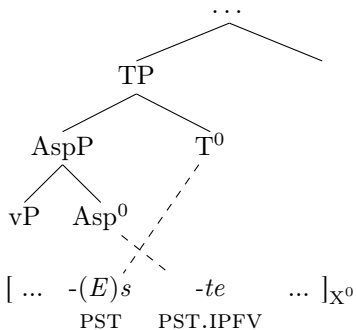
No Mirror-Principle violation

(26)



Mirror-Principle violation and Asp-inversion rule

(27)



(28) Asp-inversion rule after $-(E)ss$

$$[\dots \text{Asp}^0 \dots \text{T}^0/\text{MOD}^0 \dots]_{\mathbf{x}^0} \rightarrow [\dots \text{T}^0/\text{MOD}^0 \text{Asp}^0 \dots]_{\mathbf{x}^0}$$

Grammaticalization of *-keyss*

MiK causative *-key ho-* + resultative *-E is(i)* → MoK epistemic modal *-keyss*

- (29) a. MiK causative *-key ho-*

Nay WANG-*s* *mozom-ol* *culki-si-key*

I king-GEN mind-ACC rejoice-HONS-CON

hwo-li-ngi-ta.

do.1-VOL-HON_{Addr}-DECL

‘I shall make king’s mind rejoice.’ (1447 *Sökpo sangjöl* 24:42)

- b. MoK epistemic modal *-keyss*

Ku chayk caymiiss-keyss-ta.

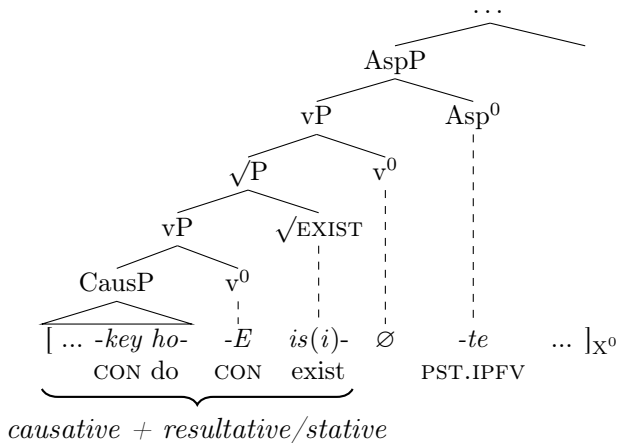
that book be.entertaining-MOD-DECL

‘That book looks entertaining (lit. That book would be entertaining).’

15th century: causative + resultative/stative

No Mirror-Principle violation

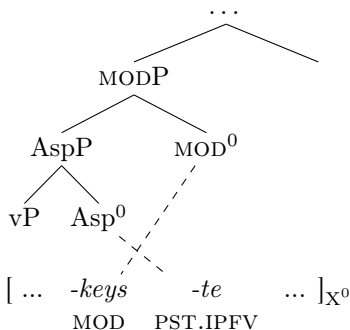
(30)



Late-18th century: modal

Mirror-Principle violation and Asp-inversion rule

(31)

(32) Asp-inversion rule after *-keyss*

$$\begin{aligned}
 & [\dots \text{Asp}^0 \dots T^0 / \text{MOD}^0_{-(u)li/-keyss} \dots]_{X^0} \\
 & \rightarrow [\dots T^0 / \text{MOD}^0_{-(u)li/-keyss} \text{Asp}^0 \dots]_{X^0}
 \end{aligned}$$

Reanalysis yielding a simpler post-syntactic module

The reanalysis was facilitated because:

- A simpler post-syntactic module was preferred for the given PLD.
- The growing number of the token serving as positive evidence for *-te*'s position higher than the grammaticalized morphemes.

	15th c.	18th c.	21th c.
	<i>-te</i> as Asp ⁰		<i>-te</i> as EVID ⁰
Input X ⁰	[... Asp ⁰ ... MOD ⁰ ...] _{X⁰}	[... Asp ⁰ ... MOD ⁰ /T ⁰ ...] _{X⁰}	[... MOD ⁰ /T ⁰ EVID ⁰ ...] _{X⁰}
Asp-inversion	↓ MOD Asp	↓ MOD/T Asp	↓
VI	↓ -(u)li-le	↓ -(u)li-le/-(E)s-te	↓ -keys-te/-(E)ss-te
# of PS rules	1	2 or 3	0

Table: Post-syntax before and after the structural reanalysis

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Implication of the current analysis

- Implication of the current analysis: *-te*'s reanalysis is structurally driven, rather than semantically motivated.
- The prediction: the full-fledged evidential meaning emerged after the reanalysis had been complete.

The prediction is borne out.

Completion of the semantic change: mid 19th c.–early 20th c.

- The person constraint on agentive subjects characteristic of the Modern Korean *-te* did not exist until the mid-19th century (Choi 2015; Lee 2020).

(33) a. 1790 *Inŏdaebang* (1:22b)

Mwusom YENKWO-lwo kutayci SILYAK-ul
 which reason-INS such break.a.promise-ACC
ho-siop-te-nkwo?
 do-HONS-TE-Q

‘Why did (you) break your promise?’

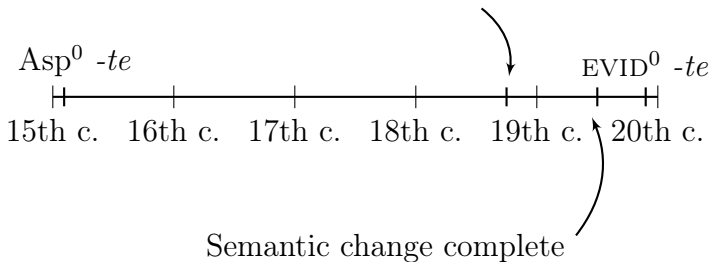
b. 1882 *Cengceng Inŏdaebang* (2:8a)

Mwusun yenkwo-lwo kutayci silyakhe-sy-es-swo?
 which reason-INS such break.a.promise-HONS-PST-Q

Complete evidential meaning later than the reanalysis

(34) Timeline regarding *-te*'s reanalysis

Structural reanalysis complete



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Takeaway

- The syntax-morphology mismatch regarding MiK *-te* and *-(u)li* is an accidental result of grammaticalization, resulting in post-syntactic complexity.
- The increased post-syntactic complexity in the post-17th century resulted in a structural reanalysis of *-te*.
- The reanalysis effectively removed the post-syntactic complexity suggesting that Roberts's (2022) simplicity preference operates on the post-syntactic module.

Loose end

- How do we model the ‘tipping-point (Yang 2016)’ of the structural reanalysis?
- What was the status of the nodes filled with the grammaticalized morphemes before the grammaticalization?
 - MOD in the pre-15th c.
 - EVID⁰ in the 15th c.
 - Reintges (2015: 131) suggests that terminal nodes of discourse-related projections may be initiated with null heads and be filled with overt exponents later on.
- The formalization of the semantic change after the reanalysis
- Cross-linguistic test

ACC	accusative	FUT	future
ADN	adnominal	GEN	genitive
AGR	agreement	HON	honorific
ASS	assertive	INS	instrumental
CAUS	causative	IPFV	imperfective
CON	connective	MOD	modal
COP	copula	NOM	nominative
DECL	declarative	PST	past
DEP	dependent	VOL	volitive
EVID	evidential		

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Thank you!

Person constraint of *-te* on agentive subjects

In Modern Korean, first- and second-person subject cannot be used as an agentive subject in declarative and interrogative sentence, respectively, in the presence of *-te* (Lee 2020; Song 2020).

- (35) a. * *Nay-ka keki ka-te-la.*
 I-NOM there go-TE-DECL

‘I went there.’

- b. * *Ney-ka keki ka-te-nya/nka?*
 you-NOM there go-TE-Q/Q

‘Have you gone there?’

(Lee 2020: 331)

Person constraint of -te on agentive subjects

Such a constraint is not found in Middle Korean.

- (36) a. *Nay lwongtamho-ta-la.*
 I.NOM joke-PST.IPFV.1-DECL
 ‘I was joking.’ (1447 *Sŏkpo sangjŏl* 6:24b)
- b. *Ne-y i NYEM-ul twuis-te-nta?*
 you-NOM this thought-ACC place-TE-Q
 Have you thought this? (1459 *Wŏrin sŏkpo* 9:35)

The past meaning is obligatory only in MiK

Modern Korean: does not have to describe past action.

- (37) a. *Taum tal-pwuthe kilum-kaps-i olu-te-la.*
 next month-from oil-price-NOM rise-EVID-DECL
 ‘The oil price rises from next month.’ (Song 2020: 416)
- b. *Cepen tal-pwuthe kilum-kaps-i ol-ass-te-la.*
 last month-from oil-price-NOM rise-PST-EVID-DECL
 ‘The oil price rose last month.’

Lenition of /t/ in post-copular position

In MiK, /t/ becomes /l/ when it is placed to the right of the copula -i.

(38) $t \rightarrow l$ / Copula -i __

a. After $\sqrt{\quad}$: no lenition

ho-ta

do-DECL

b. After copula: lenition

kwiskes-i-la.

ghost-COP-DECL

Lenition of /t/ in post-copular position

-te is also subject to the lenition rule.

(39) Asp *-te* $\rightarrow$ *-le*

a. After $\sqrt{\quad}$: no lenition

ho-te-la.

do-PST.IPFV-DECL

b. After copula: lenition

kwiskes-i-le-la.

ghost-COP-PST.IPFV-DECL

Lenition of /t/ in post-copular position

The lenition rule is not reducible to the general phonology.

(40) After HON_S *-(u)si* and HON_{Addr} *-ngi*: No lenition

a. *ho-si-ta*

do-HON_S-DECL

b. *ho-si-ni-ngi-ta*

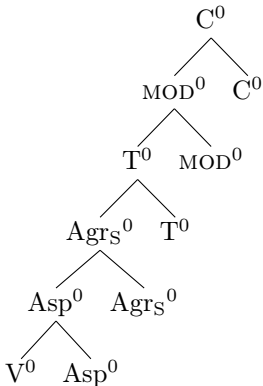
do-HON_S-ASS-HON_{Addr}-DECL

The post-*(u)li* environment also exhibits the same allomorphy with the post-copular position.

Derivation

- (12a) *TUKho* *-si* *-li* *-le* *-la*
 obtain -HON_S -MOD -PST.IPFV -DECL
 ‘would be going to obtain’ (hon.)

- (41) Input complex head ($V^0 = [\sqrt{\text{OBTAIN}} v^0]_{v^0}$)

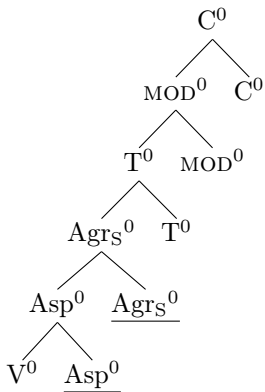


Derivation

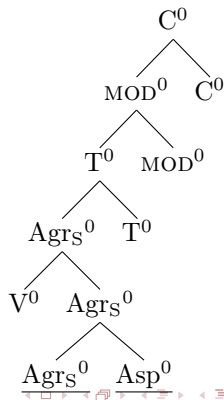
- (12a) *TUKho* *-si* *-li* *-le* *-la*
 obtain -HON_S -MOD -PST.IPFV -DECL
 ‘would be going to obtain’ (hon.)

- (42) Asp-inversion: Step 1

a.



b.

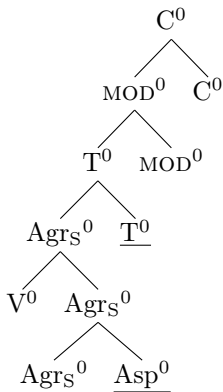


Derivation

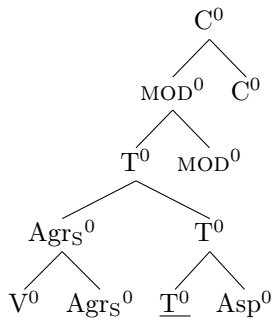
- (12a) *TUKho* -si -li -le *-la*
 obtain -HON_S -MOD -PST.IPFV -DECL
 ‘would be going to obtain’ (hon.)

- (43) Asp-inversion: Step 2

a.



b.

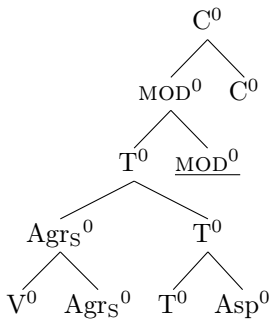


Derivation

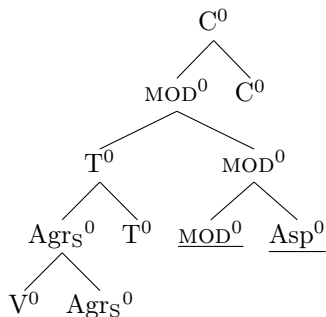
- (12a) *TUKho* -si -li -le *-la*
 obtain -HON_S -MOD -PST.IPFV -DECL
 ‘would be going to obtain’ (hon.)

- (44) Asp-inversion: Step 3

a.



b.



Derivation

- (12a) *TUKho* *-si* *-li* *-le* *-la*
 obtain -HON_S -MOD -PST.IPFV -DECL
 ‘would be going to obtain’ (hon.)

- (45) Asp-inversion: Vocabulary Insertion

